

Akash Yumnam and a new-look India chase sepak takraw glory

India men's sepak takraw team, led by veteran Akash Yumnam and a new generation of players, heads to Aichi-Nagoya with **growing confidence** after a gold at the Asian Sepak Takraw Championship.

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There is a medal cabinet in Akash Yumnam's house in the village of Laipham Khunou near Manipur's capital, Imphal. It contains almost everything a sepak takraw player could want. Almost. The bronze medal he won at the 2018 Asian Games is there.

So are the other medals accumulated through a career that has now stretched across nearly a decade and a half. His young son sometimes looks at the cabinet, switches its light on and off, and stares at the medals without yet understanding what they mean. Akash does. But he also knows what is missing.

"I need to win another medal," he says.

At 30, Akash is widely considered the best player and the senior statesman of the Indian men's sepak takraw team heading to the Asian Games in Aichi-Nagoya. It will be his fourth Asian Games. If there's anyone in India who can dream of another medal, it's Akash.

Arun Kumar, a 23-year-old Delhi player competing at his second Asian Games, agrees. "Akash *bhai* is the best player in India. He's probably among the top five strikers in the world," he says.

There is little showmanship in the way Akash talks about himself. His teammates do the boasting for him. Bobby Kumar, a 21-year-old from Bihar who has emerged as one of India's younger attacking options, says Akash's greatest quality is his discipline. "He will warm up in the morning and evening. He will take care of himself — food and water, everything on time. He won't adjust for a day. He will go and go, no matter what," Bobby says.

That routine has allowed Akash to remain at the highest level in a sport that demands extraordinary athleticism. Sepak takraw is an unforgiving game: players leap, twist and strike a ball with their feet, legs, heads and bodies,

often in movements that look closer to martial arts or gymnastics than conventional ball sports.

Age so far hasn't caught up with him. "I think if I keep physically fit, I can keep playing. I think I could play the 2030 Asian Games as well. But I don't want to think so far into the future. For now I want a medal," he says. If anything, the strangest thing about Akash's career may be that sepak takraw was not his first love.

Growing up in Manipur, like most other children his age, he played football. He was around 11 when two coaches, Rakeshwar Singh and Jamendra Singh, showed up at the village playground and started training children in a new sport.

The game's movements seemed crazy, but they also seemed familiar. Akash's football background helped him understand the aerial movements almost immediately — the rolling shot, one of sepak takraw's signature attacking movements, was not completely alien to someone who had known how to execute a bicycle kick. He started playing seriously around 2009. Within a few years, he was moving through the age-group ranks: sub-junior, junior, then senior competition. By 2013 he had already played several international tournaments.

All through this, another possibility beckoned. Football.

TOTAL MEDALS
AT STAKE

24